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stacker news weekly zine



sep 12 - sep 19

issue #71

967 731

stacker news zine

brings you the best posts
from this week on `stacker.news`.
What was zapped, what was not
zapped, and what was *downzapped*,
that's already history.

< created by [@plebpoet](#) >

Note from the Editor

Stacker News is all
about healthy
incentives for
online discussion.
Then DOWNZAP came
along...and it's
great to learn new
things!

By the way, I hope
you spent your
daily rewards on
this zine.

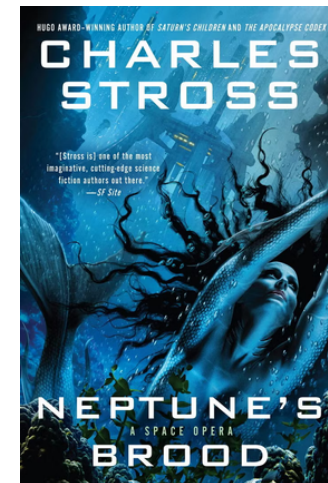


NEPTUNE'S BROOD: THE FIRST BITCOIN NOVEL

19k sats | 29 comments | [@siggy47](#) 12 Sep
bitcoin BooksAndArticles

I can't believe I never heard of Neptune's Brood until last week. In my defense, I am not much of a sci fi reader, nor have I ever heard of it mentioned in any bitcoin podcast, conference, article or on any social media site.

The author, Charles Stross, is a fairly well known science fiction writer. The book, part of the Freyaverse series, was shortlisted for the Hugo Award for Best Science Fiction/Fantasy Novel of 2014. I discovered that Nobel Prize Winner and Widely Recognized Douchebag Paul Krugman really liked Stross's treatment of "interstellar finance." This fact alone almost caused me to dismiss "Neptune's Brood", but curiosity got the best of me.



So why is this book so obscure? Most people I know who are obsessed with bitcoin are also obsessed with science fiction. Even more incredibly, it has the distinction of being the first novel in history to mention bitcoin. That's what my research tells me, and I stand by that assertion until I'm proven wrong. Start hunting.

Full disclosure - I have not read the book, so I am not calling this post a book review. However, I did read a lot about the book, and my copy is in the mail. From what I have learned, bitcoin is not just mentioned, but it is critical to the plot.

The novel opens with a quote from David Graeber's book, *Debt: The First 5,000 Years*. I did read that book, and while I enjoyed it and learned a lot, I didn't generally buy his debt over barter theory thesis.

Regarding the plot, I have seen it described as a financial sci fi novel. Set in the future, bitcoin forms the basis for an interstellar financial system because it is theft-proof. Each coin is cryptographically signed by the mind of its owner.

Although I don't know the details, money is broken up into three types:

> *Fast money is ordinary day-to-day cash, medium money covers investment instruments within a single planetary system, and slow money is reserved for interstellar investment that takes centuries or millennia to mature, with slow-money transactions relying on a three-way cryptoverification scheme that trades at one-third the speed of light.*

Some reviewers say the writing is too dense, and the author uses too many obscure words. It is also criticized for spending too much time lecturing about the "slow money" financial system rather than focusing on plot or character development. As bitcoiners we may have a greater tolerance for financial discussion.

< continued online >

ARE YOU ZAPPING MORE TODAY?

442 sats \ 19 comments \ @wackster
15 Sep AskSN



The rewards pool is an impossible 2.4 million sats. So, are you zapping more, anon?

Yes	78.1%
No	21.9%

32 votes \ poll ended

COMMENTS

220 sats \ 1 reply \ @grayruby 15 Sep
Yes mostly because my wallet is fat from the recent surge in rewards. Not chasing the big pool.

209 sats \ 0 replies \ @optimism 15 Sep
Zapping less. Unless I keep having deep threads in saloon, then I'm zapping more, but not the kind of zaps that milk bootie

195 sats \ 1 reply \ @ek 15 Sep



179 sats \ 0 replies \ @jasonb 15 Sep
It'd be hard not to. I lost my cowboy hat today. :(

92 sats \ 0 replies \ @SimpleStacker 15 Sep
nice try fed



THE ZOUND OF DESCENDING INTO SIMPLICITY...

18.1k sats \ 15 comments \ @jasonb
15 Sep Music math ideasfromtheedge

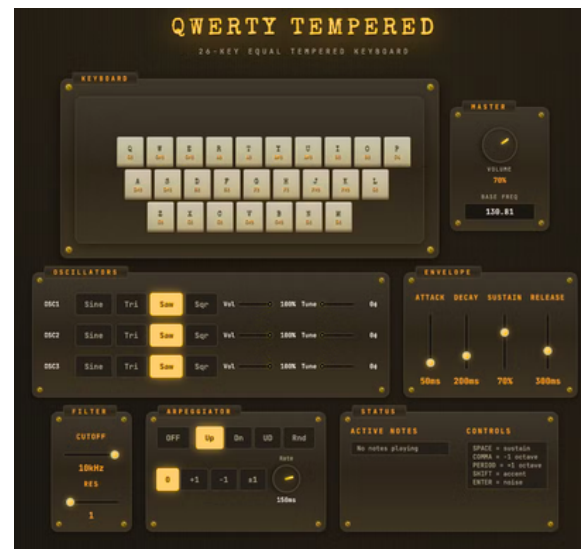
For a while now, I've been experimenting with making digital instruments. I've released some of the more "finished" ones at <https://thealternativedesktopsynthesizer.garden/>



Some are simply goofy, like this synth that is made to look like windows in the 90s. It doesn't do anything particularly exciting, but you could bring a controller and a laptop to a gig, and it will function just fine.

Others, like this one, which literally changes the pitch of your upper notes to match whatever tuning system you setup in the bass, legitimately might affect your playing and help you make some different music than if you just plugged in any old Moog emulator.

Others may only work at home, like this one, tempered to your keyboard.



Nevertheless, there are options to really create some new music with it. I like finding some good sounds, and then just typing the verbal thoughts in my head.

One is a [polyrhythmic drum machine](#) for DJs that are going for that filling-the-dancefloor-with-nerds sound.

Anyway, @SimpleStacker was out bot-bating last week and straight up blew my mind with this post on the Collatz Conjecture. Dude! I love learning about this kind of thing. It's kind of like the opposite of Conway's Game of Life. With this set of rules, you can start with infinite complexity and always end in the same simple sequence.



Anyway, through persistent badgering, I learned that he had made this cool visualizer for it with his son, and I immediately wanted to hear it as well. So...I would like to share with you **Hailstone Harmonics**. It may not be the most functional herb in my garden, but you can definitely get some pretty sounds (the rhythms of the bass in particular) out of it.

Make sure to play with all the options below the graph/keyboard too! :)

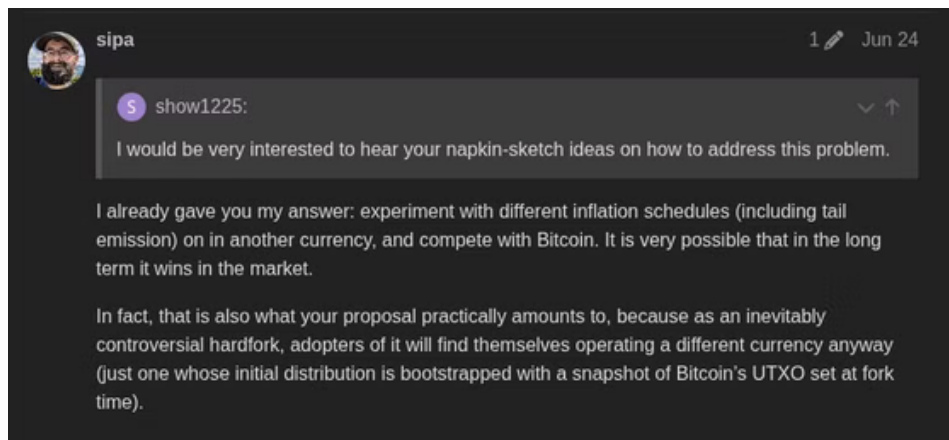


IS STARTING ANOTHER COIN THE BEST WAY TO FIX BITCOIN?

11.5k sats \ 46 comments \ @Scoresby
15 Sep AskSN bitcoin

Forgive my clickbait title, but in setting up this week's Bitdev's list I came across this delving post about "fixing" Bitcoin's security budget via tail emissions and other convoluted mechanics. I don't really care about that.

I found this response from Pieter Wuille (aka sipa) thought-provoking:



We've recently experienced this dynamic: a group of Bitcoiners were very dissatisfied with the fact that arbitrary data was being embedded in Bitcoin blocks and they thought that the rules should be changed to attempt to limit such data. We spent a fiery couple years arguing about the details of changing Bitcoin, but in the end they ended up with a new coin. Kinda wish they had just done that from the beginning.



Bitcoin has some problems. Indeed, it would be rather startling if it was the case that Satoshi got everything right right off the bat. The history of Bitcoin is littered with the scorch marks of people who wanted it to change in a certain way and who ended up leaving to start their own thing.

This leads me to wonder, if, instead of trying to get Bitcoin to adopt any given change,

Maybe the best way to improve bitcoin is to launch a new coin

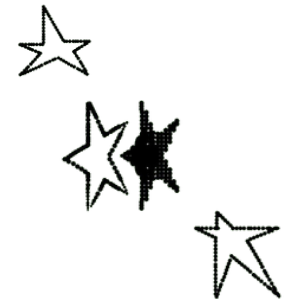
Of course, as we are seeing with bcashjr, it's not quite so simple as that. There is a quality of being Bitcoin that comes from the fact that it was first. I've heard people talk about this like the immaculate conception. Their theology is horrible, but the common sense point comes across: Bitcoin's launch may have been a bit of a perfect storm.

And this is where I wonder if Wuille isn't wrong: it's easy enough to tell someone to go try it on a new coin, but I think it's very likely that even some hypothetical coin that is better than BTC will fail simply because the dynamics of launching a new coin.

I know that there was a time when Bitcoin Maximalism meant that all the things will be done on Bitcoin and that the standard way of viewing the shitcoins was that many of them were testing out things that might eventually come to bitcoin (eg Mimble Wimple on Litecoin), so maybe Wuille is just saying what has always been said.

I do love the idea of the market always being the answer, and when I think about the current process by which we attempt to change bitcoin, it strikes me that the market is not really involved at all. I would much rather have Covenant Coin compete in the market with BTC to see how much market participants value each coin.

Watching the bcashjr launch -- while humorous and highly entertaining -- has also given me pause: go launch your own coin is maybe not such a realistic suggestion as might be assumed.



< follow the discussion online >



MEME MONDAY



393 sats \ 5 comments \ @sn
14 Sep memes

112 sats \ 1 reply \ @ek 14 Sep



10 sats \ 0 replies \ @mkmlloom 16 Sep



REFLECTING A BIT ON THE ZAP WARS

212.9k sats \ 133 comments \ @Undisciplined
16 Sep meta econ

We've been talking about downzapping a bunch. Obviously, the rewards are absolutely wild with some stackers receiving 6-figure payouts. The discussion on the most recent SNL reminded me that I wanted to write up some of my thoughts about this situation.

I wrote about Incentivizing Downzapping and how Punishment is a Public Good a couple of years ago. Check those out for background to my thoughts here.

Are the incentives broken?

A prevailing sentiment seems to be that the incentives on SN are not working to curate content (and maybe they aren't). We should be cautious about overreacting to the actions of a particular bad actor, especially in the short term, though.

We're seeing general SN activity increasing (zaps, unique stackers, item creation), as the boosting vs downzapping battle rages. This is part of the mechanics of the site and it's at least directionally having the self-correcting effect we hope to see. More users making good content, supported by more zapping, makes boosting stuff to the top more costly for scammers and, more importantly, is exactly what we want for SN.

I've lived through a few other periods of fervor about the incentives being broken, usually ignited by a particular bad actor seemingly getting away with something. I urged caution and patience in those episodes too and in short order the self-correcting mechanisms we have in place did seem to kick in.

Ultimately, though, incentives drive outcomes by affecting aggregate behavior, not necessarily each individual's. Any given individual can have utterly bizarre preferences and with sufficient resources they can do undesirable things.

If we think the incentives have mostly been working to curate content well, then we should let this situation breathe and see how it develops. Hemorrhaging sats to promote your scam to people who are wise to it is not sustainable behavior and unsustainable behaviors burn themselves out.

Are direct confrontations the solution?

Another aspect I've been thinking about is whether getting into a Downzap War is even the strategically correct move. The natural half-life on visibility from boost and zap decay is a powerful mechanism, especially for those of us with supposedly low time-preference.



Might this scammer have passed silently into the night, if not engaged in a big battle for visibility? Once egos get involved, behaviors can become extreme and entrenched.

What if, instead of directly challenging offending posts through a downzap confrontation, territory owners put their new (arguably ill-gotten and undeserved) revenue towards boosting the good content on SN?

Punishers go hard

Something I didn't mention in my post about punishment is that once someone decides to engage in punishment, they are often willing to expend quite a lot of resources on it. We're seeing that now with enormous downzaps that are well beyond what we see zapped towards good content.

What's curation worth to you?

It's sort of odd that punishers are willing to spend more on punishment than they are on support. It's all just curation, after all. Moving someone down 10 spots is the same as moving those 10 people up 1 spot, except that the sats go out community wide instead of to the producers of the better content. What I think is being revealed by very large downzapping is that some people value the curation of the front page of SN far beyond what they've been putting towards zaps. I've been banging on about this forever (just scroll through my top discussion posts), but it still seems to me like stackers haven't internalized the rational self-interest value of zapping the content they like.

For your own sake, zap big and zap often.

How to do wanted posters

@Car pitched the idea of wanted posters as a mechanism for flagging scammy bullshit but didn't offer @k00b any real way of implementing them in a fashion that is emergent from the community.

This is a place where I think relying on our global trust scores is valuable. Any post that's underwater with trust-weighted, time-discounted zaps vs downzaps could be tagged with a wanted poster to alert readers of SN that the upstanding members of this community think caution is warranted with those posts.

TL;DR

Stacker News has an impressive array of self-correcting mechanisms, but they are not instantaneous. Think about what you want SN to be and whether you're already doing what you think you should towards that end, before pushing to change the rules.

I very much look forward to a lively discussion about this.

> > >



DISCUSSION

801 sats \ 38 replies \ @optimism 16 Sep

> *It's sort of odd that punishers are willing to spend more on punishment than they are on support. [...] far beyond what they've been putting towards zaps*

I think that this is only true if we forget that when the zapwar was the other way around earlier this year, roughly the same people were actively upzapping downzapped posts. But upzaps aren't recycled as much as downzaps (or as they could be if stackers were on board), and therefore upzapping is way more costly (especially when downzaps were 3x in the first war.)

I personally downzapped more in absolute numbers of sats than I upzapped in the previous 2 wars (about 2x), but, from a money-that-I-spent minus recycled-money-from-rewards/boosts p.o.v., I actually spent a lot more non-free sats the previous rounds than I am spending now. The previous rounds hurt me much harder than this one, but that only goes for me. Others got hurt real hard this round.

Stackers weren't really willing to defend a principle back then, and stackers aren't really willing to defend a principle now. It's still the same shit. Everyone is fishing for rewards and it's pathetic.

> *boosting the good content on SN?*

I am looking forward to stackers that made up to 1M sats from boosts, to zap all the high quality evergreen posts with 1M sats so that they're ranked at the top again, and then all the pretty good posts with 500k so that they rank underneath. I'm sure that learned people also understand that upzapping good content with millions of sats is much less capital efficient than downzapping the few posts that are bad content with a few million sats.

661 sats \ 11 replies \ @SimpleStacker 16 Sep

What if the size of the rewards pool was not publicized?

And what if distribution times were randomized?

You get the same incentivized behavior, but because the connection to actions is more diffuse, you might get less distorted behavior.

687 sats \ 7 replies \ @0xbtcminer 16 Sep

> *What's curation worth to you?*

For me, the main page isn't really that important anymore. I still pop in and have a look, but most of the time I just go straight to the new filter.

500 sats \ 2 replies \ @SimpleStacker 16 Sep

Personally, I don't think a handful of bad posts on the front page really ruin the experience for anyone

Because of that, I don't think downzapping is really motivated by front page per se. It's usually motivated by moral outrage, over Israel/Gaza, over scams, that cause a righteously indignant person to try and make sure no one sees the post at all



[BOOK REVIEW] COLONIALISM: A MORAL RECKONING



33k sats \ 24 comments \ @SimpleStacker 17 Sep
BooksAndArticles Politics_And_Law history

Review of *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*, by Nigel Biggar

NIGEL
BIGGAR

COLONIALISM

A MORAL
RECKONING

The strange inconsistency of the modern left

Observe Western politics long enough and you'll inevitably come across the strange inconsistency of the modern left. This strange inconsistency is perhaps no better illustrated than in the phrase "Queers for Palestine"---because why does it make sense for queers to support a culture that's explicitly hostile to them, and even if they support Palestinian rights, why does it make sense to them to attach queer identity to that support?

Observe Western politics for some time longer and you may eventually conclude that the unifying theme of the modern left is anti-colonialism. That the primary project of

the modern left is to erase all vestiges of influence from the time of European and Christian cultural dominance. This theory of the left, I believe, carries much more explanatory power than other theories. For example, some people say that the left is concerned primarily with liberating the oppressed. But if the left cared primarily about oppressor/oppressed relationships, then why do they not speak up about Chinese oppression of Uighurs, or Nigerian oppression of Christians? Categories of oppression only seem to matter when it is Western culture doing the oppression. So the unifying theme that best explains the modern left is not anti-oppression, but anti-colonialism.

One can see why anti-colonialism is attractive

And one can see why anti-colonialism would be an attractive ideology. From a purely empirical perspective, it's hard to deny that the advantaged position of certain demographic groups derive at least in part from historical European Christian hegemony. It is also impossible to deny that Western cultural imperialism gave rise to many human rights abuses suffered by non-Westerners at the hands of Westerners. Introspection is always and everywhere a virtue, so for the Westerner, it makes good sense to introspect about past wrongs and to apologize for them. For the non-Westerner, such introspection may be encouraged as a means to either achieve reconciliation or to garner material concessions.

What's missing is the relevant counterfactual

But what's missing from the anti-colonial impulse is an assessment of the relevant counterfactual. Yes, Western colonialism led to abuses. But what other abuses, and how many and to what degree, would have happened had the Europeans not engaged in their colonial past? Can we fairly say that the world have been better had the Europeans not engaged in their colonial past? By what measure do we judge the result of Western imperialism versus the cultures that they displaced?

< c o n t i n u e d >

A fair look at the spectrum of humanity involved

Nigel Biggar tackles these questions in *Colonialism: A Moral Reckoning*. A moral philosopher, (like Adam Smith), Nigel Biggar is interested in telling the moral history of European colonialism, with a fair look at the entire spectrum of the humanity involved: from the European nobles who made policy from afar, to the lowly settler engaged in conflict with the natives, to the natives with varied attitudes towards European colonization, to the modern academics who look back at these stories through agenda-tinted lenses.

A much needed corrective to anti-colonial tropes

The book is a much needed corrective to modern anti-colonial tropes. Biggar does not shy away from acknowledging some of the horrors that resulted from European colonization, but he rightly points out that European colonization did much good around the world too. For example, he points out the British bore as much economist cost in trying to abolish slavery around the world as it profited from the slave trade prior to abolition. He also demonstrates, through primary sources, the wide extent to which many Europeans were motivated by genuine humanitarian sentiments.

Most importantly, he highlights the messy nature of human morality, showing us that it doesn't make sense to paint any culture with too broad of a brush, Western or otherwise. Within the European colonizers there were both saints and sinners, abolitionists and slavers, and the whole spectrum of humanity; just so amongst the native populations as well. Among the natives there were those who would have enslaved each other were it not for the European abolitionists, and there were others who welcomed European traditions as a relief against their oppressive native traditions. The picture that Biggar paints is simply one of messiness: when two cultures come into contact with each other, stuff happens; often, every kind of stuff you can imagine.

Least sympathetic group: modern academics

Perhaps the group that comes across least sympathetic in Biggar's analysis is the modern left leaning academic. Biggar shows that much of modern scholarship is biased and agenda driven. He does this by showing examples of modern academics taking historical quotes out of context so that they can paint a more damning picture of European attitudes than is deserved. Biggar instead shows that European attitudes were varied and diverse, and that claims about European racism are often unfair and overstated.

...

< k e e p r e a d i n g o n l i n e f o r
h i s t o r i c a l q u o t a t i o n s >

Conclusion

To conclude, I'd recommend this book to anyone interested in understanding European colonial history and anyone who is looking for a corrective to modern anti-colonialist sentiments.

THE EASIEST ORANGEPILLING OF MY LIFE: A WAITER, SOME CHURROS, AND ONE QUESTION

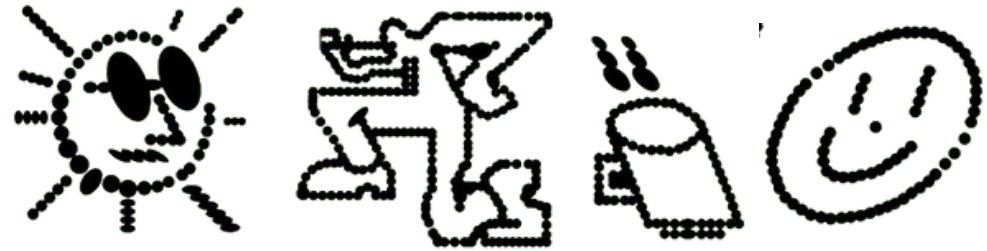


7921 sats \ 16 comments \ @satoshiplanet
19 Sep bitcoin bitcoin_beginners



I walked into a café in my city and dropped my usual "I'll pay with Bitcoin."

The waiter, who's also the owner, looked at me and said: "Oh, so you have Bitcoin?" I replied: "Of course, don't you? I want to pay you with sats, how much is it?", and then the floodgates opened: "But how does that work? How did you get it? Does it actually work? Is it safe?" A face full of enthusiasm I wasn't expecting.



He invited me to "churros" and we agreed to meet this afternoon to get started. I'm bringing stickers, a simple wallet, and patience, I think something is changing in people... it's not that everyone suddenly wants to buy Bitcoin, it's that there are more people than we think who have already heard of it, who are curious, who are intrigued, and who just need a little push.

A regular guy, with his café, who one day says "so you have Bitcoin?" and the next day is learning to set up a wallet, so yeah, it was the easiest orangepill of my life, he just needed someone to tell him yes, of course it's possible, it's dead simple. Now I have to explain it well, without jargon, without maximalism, without scaring him, start small and understand the basics. Has anything like this happened to any of you?

t e l l u s a b o u t i t
a t s t a c k e r . n e w s